

Chicago Tribune



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MONDAY, JANUARY 20, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



A student, left, walks with her mother on the Southwest Side of Chicago on Thursday. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Migrant students in shadow of deportation

CPS prepares as Trump inauguration promises to bring in policy changes

By Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

Chicago Public Schools wants its students and staff members to know that its buildings are public areas generally known as “sensitive locations.”

That means federal immigration agents are not permitted to enter CPS facilities unless they provide their credentials, the reason they are requesting access and a criminal judicial warrant signed by a federal judge.

But the protections for students are still uncertain and unclear to many migrant

or undocumented parents and students who are anxiously waiting for the transition of power Monday — with President-elect Donald Trump promising the largest deportation operation in United States history, starting in Chicago. (On Saturday, Tom Homan, whom Trump has tapped to head immigration enforcement, told The Washington Post that a decision had not yet been made on whether to conduct raids here this week.)

“We’ve seen on the news that they’re saying they’re going to go into schools and hospitals to take migrant students to be deported,” said Willzuly, a CPS

mother from Venezuela whose daughter goes to a school on the South Side. “That anxiety is real. We don’t know what’s going to happen.”

Willzuly, whose last name is being withheld for her safety, said her 16-year-old daughter is in a critical time of learning who to trust, and how to trust. Trump’s promises of mass deportations, she said, are teaching her to distrust the very systems that are supposed to be there to support her.

CPS sent an email in mid-January assuring parents of its commitment to safeguard immigrant rights under Trump.

■ How President Donald Trump’s deportation promise could affect children in Chicago Public Schools, **Page 2**

“Current federal law protects children’s rights to a free public education, regardless of their immigration status or their family’s immigration status. ... We are here to support you,” the email reads.

The district has provided detailed guidance to principals and staff on how to handle potential interactions with U.S. Immigration and Customs

Turn to Deportation, Page 2

MLK Day brings a call to action

Civil rights leaders see inauguration as poignant contrast

By Matt Brown
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — When Donald Trump is sworn in as president of the United States inside the Capitol’s rotunda, he will do so facing a bust of the Rev. Martin Luther King Jr. on the federal holiday commemorating King’s legacy.

It’s a disquieting contrast for some civil rights advocates who wish to fulfill King’s dream of nonviolent social revolution.

Events honoring King and advocating for his vision of a just society will occur across the nation as many in the U.S. observe the peaceful transfer of power in the capital. The concurrent events have been met with mixed feelings by civil rights leaders, who broadly reviled Trump’s rhetoric and stances on race and civil rights during his third presidential campaign.

But many leaders, including King’s own family, see the juxtaposition as a poignant contrast and a chance to refocus the work of advancing civil rights in a new political era.

“I’m glad it occurred on that day because it gives the United States of America and the world the contrast in pictures. Is this the way you want to go — or is this the way you want to go?” said the Rev. Bernice King, his youngest daughter and CEO of the King Center.

“It’s not a day that (Trump) can be the star, which he loves to be. He has to contend with that legacy on that day, regardless of how he manages it and handles it in his presentation.

Turn to MLK Day, Page 8

DCFS has made small steps in improving placement of children

But troubling issues persist in office’s handling of clients

By Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

In a court hearing last spring, the new head of the Department of Children and Family Services promised improvements in placements for children in state care, who critics say are far too often kept in jails, psychiatric wards, offices or other inappropriate settings, by the end of 2024.

Last week, DCFS Director Heidi Mueller said the agency has done better in placing children in proper settings and shared new findings showing fewer kids are sleeping in

government offices, a key subject of complaints from watchdogs. But data released at the end of last year indicates that while there were pockets of improvement during her initial months in office, troubling issues persist and the agency is far from solving its child placement problem.

Nonetheless, even a small step in the right direction was enough to win qualified praise from Cook County Public Guardian Charles Golbert, an ardent DCFS critic who in recent years has filed a number of cases that led to contempt charges against the agency.

“The good news is for the first time in years and years, DCFS seems to be on the right track, but it still has a long slog to go,”

Turn to Children, Page 4



A storm rolls in at Ohio Street Beach in Chicago on Aug. 27. **TESS CROWLEY/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Illinois had record number of weather disasters in 2024

Region not truly immune to effects of climate change

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

California’s blazing wildfires and last year’s destructive hurricanes in the Southeast are frightening examples of the dramatic impacts of climate change. Illi-

noisans might feel relatively safe from these devastating events, but recently released data shows no region is truly immune to weather disasters.

In 2024, Illinois was affected by the most billion-dollar weather and climate disasters in the state since recordkeeping began in 1980, making it the fourth-costliest year after 2012, 1993 and 2023, according to an annual report released last week by the National

■ Subzero weather grips Chicago on 40-year anniversary of record low. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration. Twelve events that touched multiple states cost Illinois a total of nearly \$4 billion in damages — nine of those were severe storms with tornadoes, hail

Turn to Disasters, Page 3

INSIDE

Cook Co. sheriff’s deputy killed in Turks and Caicos

Shamone Duncan was fatally shot in Turks and Caicos Saturday while celebrating her sister’s 40th birthday at a popular restaurant, family and authorities said. **Page 4**

First 3 hostages arrive in Israel from Gaza

Footage showed the three women walking to Red Cross vehicles in Gaza City, surrounded by a crowd that swelled into the thousands. **Nation & World**